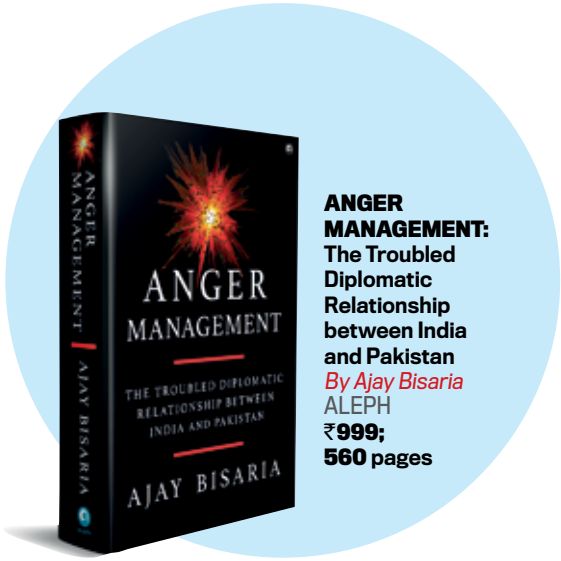
BOOKS

MANAGING PAKISTAN

By T.C.A. Raghavan

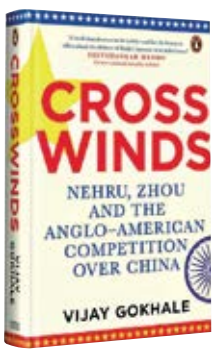


ANGER MANAGEMENT: The Troubled Diplomatic Relationship between India and Pakistan
By Ajay Bisaria
ALEPH
₹999; 560 pages

Anger Management is a history of India-Pakistan diplomacy from its earliest days. In the numerous books on this theme, Bisaria's work is distinctive not least because he has been the Indian high commissioner to Pakistan and to date the only one who has been expelled.

That distinction followed as part of the package of Pakistan's reactions to the legislative changes with regard to Jammu and Kashmir in August 2019, which led them to downgrade diplomatic relations. During Bisaria's tenure in Islamabad, another low point had been the Pulwama terrorist attack followed by the Balakot air strike. If all this suggests a monochromatic relationship of unadulterated negativism, it was also the case that work on the Kartarpur Sahib visa-free corridor began and continued uninterrupted in this period through all the nosedives in the relationship.

Bisaria's narration of how he experienced the buildup of the crisis from the time the news of the Pulwama terrorist attack spread makes for fascinating reading. Similarly, his account of Pakistan's reactions to the J&K legislative changes of August 2019 leading finally to his expulsion and other measures reveals a great deal about Kashmir or the 'K factor' in Pakistan's politics. *Anger Management* is, however, much more than a firsthand account of his tenure in Pakistan—although those details are there. It is also a reflective and analytical effort to decipher the trajectory of the relationship by looking at its history



CROSSWINDS Nehru, Zhou and the Anglo-American Competition over China
By Vijay Gokhale
VINTAGE BOOKS
₹699; 256 pages

INDIA, CHINA AND AN ANGLO-US COMPETITION

The author, a former foreign secretary, has post-retirement directed his accumulated experience and knowledge of China into three well-received books on China's political evolution and on the China-India interface. This is his fourth and is somewhat different being an immersion into the archives of four inter-governmental relationships in the 1950s: between China, the US, Britain and India. The context is the post-World War II world with an ascendant US and Britain in decline but seeking to retain influence in China and Southeast Asia. The US increasingly viewed China through the prism of the Cold War: a Communist power to be confronted or contained. The British favoured compromise and not confrontation given their economic interests in China. This meant, in effect, an Anglo-US competition over China and the Far East.

Gokhale's thesis is that this competition deeply impacted India as it sought to fashion an independent foreign policy in which China was seen as a natural partner. This thesis is examined with regard to a cluster of four specific events, each of which was a milestone in the 1950s: the recognition of the Communist government in China in 1949; the Indo-China crisis and its resolution in the Geneva Conference in 1954; and two crises in the Taiwan Straits in 1954-55 and 1958.

This thought-provoking historical work is empirically dense, but Gokhale's basic approach is also that of a policy practitioner. Like all

GOKHALE'S THESIS IS THAT AN ANGLO-US COMPETITION OVER CHINA AND THE FAR EAST IMPACTED INDIA